

Canon camera hall

The Canon camera museum is a treasure trove of information, but heres a site which tries to do that <http://goo.gl/Vr7cU>

An unlikely partnership

A more detailed take on the Canon-Nikon partnership for making the Hansa Canon <http://goo.gl/kji8o>

The plant which pioneered the camera lens system for the compact cameras was particularly interesting. DSLR lenses are not made in this plant. Before being sent for moulding, the glass is first heated at very high temperatures – at around 700 degrees Celcius, and is then moulded to form the aspherical lens element. Then that glass element is polished. It is then sprayed with a vapour deposition coating to avoid unwanted reflections. The next step is the jointing and finally edge painting. These lenses are then inspected with a laser beam to see how light scatters within. After getting an all clear signal from inspection, the lens is ready to be inserted into the camera body.

On the DSLR and compact camera assembling floor, there were teams working on various aspects of the camera. For instance, one team was assembling the components while another was switching on the camera and performing some preliminary tests. Cameras are also tested for resistance to high/low temperatures, humidity and ability to withstand vibrations. Finally, comes the cell that's involved with packaging the approved camera. The floor also has an automated guided vehicle, which is a robotic vehicle with trays full of components that are in short supply on the floor. This vehicle delivers the components to the individual cells and then finally takes the packaged products to the shipping section.

The workers at Canon Oita plant keep filing Kaizens all year round. Kaizen refers to the philosophy or practise of continuously improving processes in any area of work. At the Oita plant, we were shown two such Kaizen programs- one which helps install miniature screws at perfect right angles and another which helps save time while handing over the camera from one worker to another on the floor. The latter kaizen involved a whole sort of machine which employed a pulley system and ball bearings.

Canon museum

Canon's headquarters located in Shimomaru, Tokyo, houses the Canon camera museum. This really brought out the photography enthusiast in us, as we



1) Film cameras from the 1960s; 2) Kwanon camera- the first camera prototype to be produced in 1934; 3) Hansa Canon (1936) was the first commercial Canon camera sporting a- hold your breath- 50mm f/3.5 Nikkor lens! (Pictures: Nimish Sawant)

checked out the first ever Canon camera, which was called Kwanon back then. The story of Canon's origin goes back to the 1930s when a group of friends in Tokyo were discussing how Japan still had to make a big name in the precision industry, notably cameras, where the only quality players were from Germany ie. Leica. In 1933, the Precision Optical Laboratories was established on a third floor apartment in Tokyo and in 1934 the first camera prototype – the 35mm focal-plane shutter Kwanon camera was launched. The Kwanon was named after the thousand-armed Buddhist Goddess of Mercy. That name later became Canon as we know it today. However, the first 35mm Canon SLR camera, Canonflex, was sold. This was followed by the mass-produced Canonet in 1960.

But the real kicker came when we learned about a collaboration that would be unthinkable in present times, that between Canon and Nikon. Yes, the arch-rivals collaborated on Canon's first commercial camera- Hansa Canon, which sported a Nikkor lens. Nikon just made lenses back then and the Nikkor lens was used in Canon cameras till 1948, when Nikon came out with its first camera. Check out some of those vintage cameras showcased above.

Exploring Tokyo

Being in Tokyo and not trying out the local cuisine is like committing hara-kiri. Japanese food is much more than just plain old Sushi – a raw fish cum boiled rice concoction bordered by seaweed. We also sampled the succulent Yakitori which is a form of grilled chicken on wooden skewers oozing with barbeque sauce; crispy Tempura which to put it simply is a shrimp *pakora*; slurpy Ramen with pieces of chicken and pork. Bored with chicken and fish after a while, we swallowed all our inhibitions and dunked right into the octopus meat sushi. All the food above was washed down with a liberal amount of Japanese rice wine popularly known as Sake. It was served to us in traditional earthenware which helped keep the sake cool. It had a lovely flavour to it and no, we didn't suffer from any hangover the next day. Japanese manga culture is a very profitable business in Japan. Where else in the world can you have comics book sales of over 500 million in a year or revenues of \$3.5 billion! At a venue called Takeshita Dori, you get to see an interesting side of this same manga culture. Takeshita Dori is flooded from end to end with the uber-fashionable youth, most of whom are dressed up as their favourite manga